

ECON 488

Radical Political Economy

 University of Missouri-Kansas City |  Fall 2026

 MoWe 2:00pm–3:15pm

 Royall Hall, Rm 00213

 Aug 24 – Dec 11, 2026

 **Instructor:** Kabeer Bora, Department of Economics |  kabeerbora@umkc.edu

Course Description

Throughout this course, we will explore fundamental concepts and engage in discussions within the realms of philosophy, sociology, political science, and economics as they relate to Karl Marx's writings. The primary focus, however, will be on critically analyzing Marxist and classical economics. When needed, we will offer historical context and dive into the history of economic thought to enhance the understanding of Marx's works. Towards the end, we apply Marxian Economics to international trade.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the semester, a successful student will:

- ✓ Develop a comprehensive understanding of the fundamentals of Marxian economic theory.
- ✓ Acquire familiarity with key Marxian variables and their quantitative assessment.
- ✓ Apply Marxian economic theory to analyze real-world events empirically.
- ✓ Strengthen the ability to write about and discuss economic content in a compelling and persuasive way.

Required & Supplementary Materials

Primary text 📖

Basu, Deepankar. *The Logic of Capital: An Introduction to Marxist Economic Theory* (2022).

Recommended supplements 📖

- › Rieu, Dong-Min. *A Mathematical Approach to Marxian Value Theory* (2022)
- › Tsoulfidis, Lefteris and Persefoni Tsaliki. *Classical Political Economics and Modern Capitalism* (2019)

Additional readings will be flagged in class as needed.

🔗 Course Outline

This is a tentative outline. We will reassess pacing as we go.

1 Introduction to the Labor Theory of Value

Basu Ch. 3.1; Rieu Ch. 2; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 1.3–1.4

📖 Foundational concepts

2 A Model of Production & Marx on Money

Basu Ch. 3.1.5 & 3.2; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 1.5–1.6

3 Generation of Surplus Value

Basu Ch. 3.3 & 3.4; Rieu Ch. 4; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 1.7

4 Accumulation of Capital

Basu Ch. 3.5

5–6 Realization of Surplus Value

Basu Ch. 4.1 & 4.2; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 2.4–2.6

7 Distribution of Surplus Value

Basu Ch. 5.1, 5.2 & 5.3; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 4

8 Productive & Unproductive Labor

Basu Ch. 5.4 & 5.5; Rieu Ch. 10; Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki Ch. 9

9 Class Analysis
 Wolff & Resnick (2006), Part I, Ch. 1–2
 🔄 Framework shift: Wolff & Resnick

10 New Departures: Overdetermination
 Wolff & Resnick (2006), Part I, Ch. 3–4

11 Postcolonial Capitalism & Sanyal
 Sanyal (2007), Rethinking Capitalist Development; Wolff & Resnick Part III

12 Ground Rent
 Basu Ch. 5.3; Marx, Capital Vol. III, Part VI

13 Capitalism & Technical Change
 Basu Ch. 5.2, 6.1 & 6.2; Rieu Ch. 7

14 Transformation Problem
 Basu Ch. 7; Tsoulfidis & Tsabiki Ch. 3

15 Fall Break
 ☕ No class

16 Unequal Exchange in International Trade
 Class slides & notes; Emmanuel (1972); Amin (1976)
 🌐 Final unit

📊 Evaluation & Grading

It is your responsibility to follow Canvas announcements and to stay up to date with deadlines. The grade breakdown is:

🔍 **Quizzes**
20%

Short in-person quizzes
 (2–3 questions/week)

✍️ **Final Paper**
40%

Applied Marxian analysis
 (end-of-semester essay)

🗣️ **Presentations**
40%

Presenter (30%)
 + Discussant (10%)

Final Paper details. The objective of Marxian theory is to examine global events using the theory as a tool. Rather than getting caught up in theoretical debates, the focus is on practical applications — e.g., the gender wage gap, growing inequality in the Global South, the political economy of a particular state or industry. We will discuss specific concepts in class to equip you to articulate Marxian variables and build a compelling narrative.

Presentations & Discussant. The class will include weekly presentations, frequency depending on enrollment. Each presenter is paired with a discussant who summarises the presentation and invites clarifying questions.

🏷️ Grading Scale

A 94–100%	A– 90–93.9%	B+ 87–89.9%	B 84–86.9%	B– 80–83.9%	C+ 77–79.9%
C 74–76.9%	C– 70–73.9%	D+ 67–69.9%	D 64–66.9%	D– 60–63.9%	E 0–59.9%

❗ Late Assignments

All assignments are administered through Canvas. The system is configured to reject submissions after the deadline — *no* late assignments, exams, or projects are accepted. Stay on top of due dates listed on your class calendar. Active, regular participation is crucial for success.

📅 Important Dates

📅 Aug 24, 2026	Classes begin (full 16-week session)
🚩 Sep 7, 2026	Labor Day Holiday (university closed)
🍴 Nov 25–27, 2026	Thanksgiving Break (university closed)
☕ Nov 30 – Dec 4, 2026	Fall Break — no class for ECON 488
🕒 Dec 11, 2026	Last day of classes
🎓 Dec 14–18, 2026	Finals Week

Policies & Resources

Basic Needs

It can be challenging to do your best in class if you have trouble meeting basic needs. The UMKC Basic Needs page lists food, housing, and financial-literacy resources. The Kangaroo Pantry is free for all UMKC students. If you need this kind of support, please reach out to UMKC Basic Needs and/or to me.

Academic Integrity

Academic honesty is essential to the intellectual life of the University. Faculty have a special obligation to expect high standards; students have a special obligation to meet them. Academic dishonesty — including cheating, plagiarism, unauthorized use of artificially generated content, or sabotage — is adjudicated through the University of Missouri Student Conduct Code.

Academic Support & Mentoring

The Department of Academic Support and Mentoring (ASM) offers peer tutoring, writing assistance, SI study groups, instructional videos, and more. Use RooLearning+ to schedule appointments and view available support for this class.

Attendance

Students are expected to attend and participate as indicated by the course modality. Per federal financial-aid rules, students not attending during the first three weeks may be administratively dropped. Notify me in advance of excused absences where possible.

Campus Safety

Inclement weather, mass-notification, and emergency-response info: see the UMKC Alert page.

UMKC Connect

Throughout the term you may receive emails about course grades or academic performance. Check your Connect dashboard regularly. Your Success Network — including academic advisor(s) and campus resources — is there to support you.

Grade Appeal Policy

Grade appeals are limited to allegedly capricious grading: assignment of a grade on grounds other than performance; application of more demanding standards than to other students; or substantial departure from the instructor's announced standards.

🕒 Accessibility & Accommodations

For disability-related accommodations or auxiliary aids, contact Student Accessibility Services as soon as possible (816-235-5612 or disability@umkc.edu). Once verified, the office will notify me and outline what we will provide.

🤝 Counseling & Wellness

UMKC students may experience stress, depression, trauma, relationship issues, or health concerns. Resources include UMKC Counseling Services (816-235-1635), Student Health & Wellness (816-235-6133), and the MindBody Connection (Student Union, 3rd floor). The UMKC Student HelpLine (816-235-2222) is also available.

👥 Equal Opportunity & Title IX

UMKC is committed to equal opportunity without unlawful discrimination on the basis of any protected identity. Compliance with UM CRR 600.000 is monitored by the Office of Equity & Title IX. If you or someone you know has experienced discrimination, harassment, or sexual misconduct, please visit the Equity & Title IX “Making a Report” page. Most UMKC employees, including instructors, are required reporters — confidential support is available through RISE, Counseling Services, and Student Health & Wellness.

🗣️ Right to Free Expression

UMKC fosters open discussion, inquiry, and expression. In our classroom, please:

- ✔️ Share airtime; listen respectfully; avoid interruptions.
- ✔️ Recognise how your identity and experience shape your perspective.
- ✔️ Speak with care; words can land as marginalising even when not intended.
- ✔️ Treat mistakes as valuable; channel defensive reactions into productive discussion.
- ✔️ Distinguish safety from comfort: discomfort can be necessary for learning.

🚩 Expressions of Perceived Bias

If you experience or witness an expression of perceived bias — harassment, bullying, microaggressions, marginalisation — you may report through the Equity & Title IX “Making a Report” page. Confidential support is available through Counseling Services and RISE.